seeking help from society and officers, citizens rose to the challenge and outperformed to meet his expectations.

During the journey of the book, I spoke to several senior members of the prime minister's core COVID-19 response team which included his immediate aides as well as senior officials from the Indian government. I was able to also speak with many private folks—ranging from doctors, vaccine manufacturers to researchers and academicians—in order to accurately present the information in the book. As the end of the book drew closer, many unanswered philosophical questions remained with me mainly about what may be going through the prime minister's mind during the difficult days of the pandemic while he made crucial decisions which saved billions of lives. In an effort to understand him, I was able to sit down with him for a short tête-à-tête.

At 7, Lok Kalyan Marg, from the moment I met him, all I could see across the magnificent cobalt-blue-leather-laden, teakwood desk which separated us in his office was a determined, towering human being—replete with human emotions, just like the rest of us. It became all the more important to me to discover the man about whom I had heard so many stories from the media. Some which allude to him being authoritarian, some which say that he takes unilateral decisions and others which paint him as such an intimidating figure who people are afraid to speak in front of. From the many questions I was able to ask him, I will present here those which enabled me to see his vision more clearly than ever. I'd like for you, my readers, to discover him just the way I was able to, vicariously through my words.

At the outset, I asked him, 'Mr Prime Minister, in the darkest days of the pandemic, when there was no hope for India, what kind of pressure did you feel knowing that saving 138 crore lives depended on your decisions?'

'Look,' he said. 'Ever since I took office, it has been my resolve to identify and fix the weaknesses in the way the Indian government functions. Let me give you an example. The biggest weakness of the Indian bureaucracy is that it is an assembled unit, not an organic unit. What this means is that our officers come from various parts of the country, spend years in service in various states, get promoted and finally make it to senior levels of leadership in departments at the Centre. How this plays out is that coordination and camaraderie between officers at senior levels in various departments doesn't come naturally. So, when I took office very early on, I